TEN DAYS OUT

Structured review panel

Complete first draft | 32,305 words including front matter and headings | 27 October 2026

All ten chapters and the three-weeks-later ending were read in full. The five Round 1 reviews were prepared independently before their authors saw the other reviews. These are simulated reviewer perspectives, not five human readers or a sales study. Ratings assess the current manuscript from each role's priorities; they are not predicted Amazon review averages. Full spoilers follow. Chapter references and short quotations refer to the supplied manuscript. No actual cover or retail blurb was supplied.

ROUND 1 - INDEPENDENT REVIEWS

1. THE KU READER

Verdict: I would finish for Beth, the island, and the car-deck showdown, but I would not automatically download Book 2.

Rating: 3.5/5.

Three biggest strengths

1. **Beth earns my attention before the hero arrives.** The cold reefer, binder checks, and discreet plate photographs in Chapter 1 show a woman doing a real job well. Her stopping herself from rushing to the damaged ferry in Chapter 2 is particularly good: she has an impulse, evaluates it, and changes course. In Chapter 9, her deck knowledge wins the encounter, and she still rescues the man who tried to kill her. That is a heroine I want to follow.

2. **Working together creates believable attraction.** The confined generator shed in Chapter 3, the scar and kiss in Chapter 4, and the trauma-kit joke in Chapter 5 are more appealing than interchangeable descriptions of muscles. "It's a very disappointing kit" is the kind of unforced humor that makes two frightened adults briefly feel like a couple. His respect for her expertise is attractive.

3. **The second half delivers events worth staying for.** The fire and crossing in Chapter 5, the failed extraction in Chapter 6, the churchyard escape in Chapter 7, and the dark deck in Chapter 9 escalate the danger. Tess's interrupted "Water side-" matters emotionally even when I already suspect her. The saltines and Ned's hearing aid give the aftermath a life beyond the arrests.

Three biggest problems

1. **I am ahead of Beth for too long.** Tess becomes suspicious in Chapter 2, when Beth tells her she is home and then answers "You" when Dane asks who knew. By Chapter 3, the log, booster, money pressure, skipper, and Ned's confidences make Tess my leading candidate. Chapter 6 is particularly frustrating: Beth hears "local emergency management," knows Tess has that job, and dismisses the connection. I can accept loyalty making her reluctant; I need to feel the reluctance instead of being asked to overlook the evidence.

2. **Chapter 8 gives me reunion sex before enough reconciliation.** "The shed had been an interview" in Chapter 7 is a serious romantic injury. Dane reporting himself matters, and Beth's "The parking lot's yours. You carry her. Not me"

is strong. But neither settles how she will distinguish his affection from his assessment next time. They are having sex again by one o'clock. I need one substantial act or exchange that makes her renewed trust convincing.

3. **The emotional temperature barely varies.** Chapters 3-4 contain a great deal of watching, counting, equipment work, and meaningful silence. Even during sex, exits, clocks, the case, and her father's equipment compete for attention. I want another laugh, an awkward admission, a disagreement that is not operational, or a desire that belongs to their ordinary lives. Their competence attracts me; it cannot do all the work of making me love them together.

Change first: Expand the Chapter 8 repair before the third sex scene. Trade a repeated suspicion passage or some generator procedure for it; a fourth sex scene would not solve this problem.

Would I finish? Yes. The first serious skim risk is Chapter 3 into the first half of Chapter 4. The kiss and then the fire recover my attention. There is no firm DNF point for this simulated reader.

Heat expectation: The open-door promise is fulfilled in Chapters 5, 6, and 8. I would call the overall experience approximately **3/5 heat, not 4/5**: explicit, relatively brief, and restrained. Chapter 5 turns mutual rescue into intimacy; Chapter 6 lowers Beth's vigilance and brings Dane's disclosure about Marisol; Chapter 8 asserts a renewed choice with the professional consequences exposed. The last of those needs more emotional preparation. The lack of condoms in Chapter 5 is handled sensibly and charmingly. The scenes have different intended meanings, but similar emotional rhythms.

Book 2: I might borrow another Cutter Island romance if its couple and premise interested me. "Three harbors. One account" does not, by itself, make me want the next love story.

2. THE DEVELOPMENTAL EDITOR

Verdict: The structure is substantially built, but the mystery and protection plot depend too often on capable people postponing obvious questions.

Rating: 3.5/5.

Three biggest strengths

1. **The action grows out of Beth's life.** Chapter 1's binders, lights, stern chain, and ring buoy become Chapter 9's terrain, escape mechanism, and rescue equipment. Chapter 5 is even better: Dane must trust Beth's reading of water, reversing the usual protector dynamic. The suspense and romance are interacting rather than taking turns.

2. **Beth has a personal arc beyond accepting protection.** "Asking Ned for the wheel is asking him to be old" in Chapter 4 establishes the cost of her loyalty. Taking the wheel in Chapter 10 resolves it through action. Her father's boat, debt, unused license, and bonds with Tess and Ned give her difficulty leaving home a material basis.

3. **The major structural turns are present and correctly placed.** Chapter 5 is a strong midpoint: the refuge burns, mutual trust becomes physical, and Beth chooses to investigate. Chapter 6 increases danger; Chapter 7 creates a genuine intimate betrayal; Chapter 9 pays off the physical setup. Chapter 10 completes this relationship through repeated visits, a transfer, Christmas plans, and reciprocal love. The book does not withhold the romance ending to sell a sequel.

Three biggest problems

1. **The mystery is fair but over-signaled.** I strongly suspected Tess at the end of Chapter 2 and made her my leading explanation in Chapter 3. By Chapter 5, "Ned tells Tess" supplies the second location's route; Chapter 6 supplies emergency-management access to the third. That is too early for the stated "not obvious early" goal. Ned has a credible secret, but Dane becomes an increasingly weak leak suspect, and Russ receives suspicious gestures more often than a persuasive alternative information chain. Either rebalance access and counterevidence or make the suspense explicitly about Beth accepting a betrayal she already suspects.

2. **Dane's operational thoroughness is uneven in precisely the places the plot needs.** In Chapter 2 he accepts "I've taken care of the check-in" without asking how. After someone tries the door, he still does not establish whom Beth contacted. The truth emerges only after the Chapter 5 fire. In Chapter 6 he knows local emergency management helped arrange extraction, but does not identify that contact until Chapter 8. A protector who constantly checks sightlines should also check information routes. The failed rescue needs an equally convincing account of why no alternative response follows.

3. **The rupture, repair, and final trap evade their hardest decisions.** Dane explains his orders and trauma in Chapter 8, but gives insufficient direct accountability for mixing intimacy with assessment. Beth's trust returns too quickly. Then the text presents a safer locked-door option before choosing a trap on the grounds that "Waiting kills her." Tess needs a specific, imminent threat that makes that judgment credible. Knowing the deck makes the plan possible; it does not establish why they must choose it.

Change first: Rebuild the information and threat chain from the first check-in through the failed extraction and final trap. For each attack, establish who knew what, how it traveled, why Dane could not close the channel, and what the antagonist must do next.

Character and ending judgment: Beth's movement from inherited obligation toward chosen work and love is persuasive. Dane's movement from rigid rules toward trust needs a stronger distinction between responsible flexibility and another dangerous exception for a woman. The happy ending is present and emotionally plausible; the tidy disciplinary outcome, transfer, and licensing assurances are less well supported. Keep romantic certainty while allowing institutional uncertainty.

The brief needs one correction: Replace "a heroine who never makes a stupid choice" with a heroine whose choices follow from what she knows, whose blind spots are emotionally credible, and whose mistakes have costs. Perfect judgment would remove much of this book's best material.

3. THE LINE EDITOR / AI-PROSE SPOTTER

Verdict: The sentences have craft and specificity, but the book applies one method of emotional restraint so consistently that the leads begin to sound governed by the same style sheet.

Rating: 3.5/5.

Three biggest strengths

1. **Concrete diction belongs to this particular world.** Chain tension, wet wool, diesel, the reefer seal, and the failing bridge give Chapter 1 authority. The prose does not default to interchangeable glamour, "electric" touches, or elaborate abstractions.

2. **Several motifs change meaning and earn their recurrence.** The latch in Chapters 1-2 detects intrusion. The hearing aid develops from Ned's avoidance into Beth's demand that he listen in Chapter 8. Teaching Dane the binder in Chapter 9 pays off during the fight. Preserve those connections.

3. **The dialogue becomes individually alive when it relaxes.** The trauma-kit exchange in Chapter 5, Tess selling condoms in Chapter 6, and Russ's family-as-town-dump joke have social texture. Those moments show the register can stretch without losing its identity.

Three biggest problems

1. **Too few gestures perform too many emotional jobs.** Hands flatten, hover, stop, stay, and decline to touch. Suspicion, attraction, grief, restraint, and forgiveness repeatedly use that same choreography. There are 215 literal occurrences of "hand" or "hands" in the chapter text; the count is not an error or evidence of AI authorship. The repeated dramatic function is the problem.

Recurring device	Chapters	Editorial effect
Flat palm on an object or person	1, 2, 5, 6, 7, 9, 10	Inspection becomes an all-purpose emotional gesture.
Dane keeping his right side clear	2-5	A useful occupational detail becomes a repeatedly restored pose.
Russ removes his cap, looks into it, replaces it	3, 4, 6	The repetition resembles a stock character animation.
Dane takes the heavier jug	3, 4	Adjacent generator encounters end with the same caretaker beat.
Reaching, then stopping short	3, 8, 9, 10	Different feelings receive nearly identical punctuation.

2. **The leads differ more in vocabulary than in voice.** Beth reads water and machinery; Dane reads posture and risk. Both count, classify, withhold, and speak in compressed procedural exchanges. Dane's Chapter 2 arrival - "Pockets meant cold. Cups meant..." - shares Beth's habit of turning observation into terse conclusions. I can identify whose expertise a paragraph uses more reliably than whose temperament it expresses. His Lowell family anecdote in Chapter 4 briefly supplies the missing elasticity.

3. **The prose explains subtext, then gives it an additional closing beat.** Examples include mental filing - "put it where she put things" in Chapters 2-3 - and the explanatory tag "They both noticed" after neither character says "reefer" in Chapter 3. Corrective fragments such as "Not the cold. The gasp" in Chapter 5 and "Not where. Never where" in Chapter 9 lose force when that sentence shape becomes routine. Chapter endings repeatedly settle on a charged object: boots and a porch voice in 3, the moving pen in 4, the incomplete suspect list in 5, the exit in 6, the notebook in 7, the separating hands in 10. Several work beautifully; their cumulative similarity makes the seams visible.

The most damaging motif is the pulse as a truth verdict. Chapter 6 declares "It was the truth, all of it" after Beth feels a steady pulse. Chapter 7 acknowledges that the same steadiness tells her nothing. Chapter 10 returns to "True." The ending would be stronger if she chose to trust him on the basis of his conduct, with the touch expressing that choice.

Change first: After the structural revision, do a global redundancy and voice pass. Keep repetitions that acquire new meaning; remove repetitions that merely restore the same mood. Replacing every "hand" with a synonym would preserve the problem while damaging the concrete diction.

AI-prose judgment: The disclosed pipeline's likely signature is over-enforcement of a coherent style, not obviously careless prose. None of these features independently proves machine authorship. The editorial test is whether the reader can predict the emotional mechanism of a paragraph before reaching its end. Here, too often, the answer is yes.

4. THE KDP MARKET STRATEGIST

Verdict: This has a plausible niche as atmospheric, open-door coastal romantic suspense; exceptional spice is not its strongest selling point.

Rating: 3/5 for present market readiness.

Three biggest strengths

1. **The product can be described and differentiated.** Chapters 1-2 supply illicit cargo, a threatened deckhand, a stranded marshal, and an island whose social network becomes dangerous. Beth's work gives the cover and description something more specific to sell than a generic protector.

2. **Romantic Suspense is a defensible primary category.** The relationship is central, the danger shapes intimacy, and the three sex scenes in Chapters 5, 6, and 8 affect trust. Frank vocabulary does not make Erotica the best description of this story.

3. **The purchase has an ending.** Chapters 9-10 resolve the immediate threat and complete Beth and Dane's romance while retaining a wider case. Calling it a novella and disclosing on-page sex in the front matter already helps set expectations.

Three biggest problems

1. **The planned spice positioning risks recruiting the wrong reader.** The first kiss is in Chapter 4; sex starts in Chapter 5. The experience is controlled and procedural, with moderate explicit heat. A very-spicy promise would overstate it, while a quaint clean-romance cover could mislead in the opposite direction. State "open-door romantic suspense novella" in the retail description. The front-matter assurance that nobody the reader loves dies also removes more uncertainty than a romance HEA promise requires.

2. **The sequel hook sells a case, not the next romance.** "Three harbors. One account" in Chapter 10 tells me there is more investigation. It does not tell me whose love story comes next. Decide whether this is a sequence of complete romances with new couples or a continuing Beth/Dane suspense series. Also clarify Russ's relationship status before implying a possible pairing; the Jolene/family references are not empty space.

3. **A short book has limited revenue per completed subscription read.** At 32,305 words, length is not inherently disqualifying. But fewer normalized pages mean less page-read income than a longer equally completed book, while acquisition and production still cost money. Chapters 3-4 therefore need to earn their procedural space. Padding for page count would worsen the product.

Change first: Fix the exact audience and series promise, then build the cover, description, and Book 2 end matter around it. Keep the working-island identity and moderate open-door heat.

Packaging and current KDP rules

Non-explicit packaging is sensible. "PG-13" is not an Amazon certification or a guarantee against filtering. KDP's specific setup question covers sexually explicit images, including interior images, and explicit title/subtitle language. It is not a blanket question about whether prose contains an adult sex scene. Broader content rules and accurate metadata still apply. Answer the actual questions truthfully and make the heat clear to buyers. [S1]

My visual direction would be a storm harbor or ferry with adult romantic cues and strong title readability. No actual cover has been evaluated here.

Launch plan - recommendations, not promises about the algorithm

- **Price:** Start the revised ebook at **US $2.99**. An eligible 70% sale is about $2.09 before delivery-cost effects and applicable tax. The current U.S. 70% price band is $2.99-$12.99. Consider a brief acquisition discount when the next book is available, rather than making permanent cheapness the proposition. [S2, S3]
- **Subscription channel:** Test one **90-day KDP Select term**, with its digital exclusivity requirement understood. This makes the subscription experiment concrete without assuming the channel will supply discovery. [S4]
- **Economics:** Use the actual normalized page count after formatting. Amazon calculates KENP, and the rate varies by month and marketplace. Pure illustration: 150 normalized pages at an assumed $0.0045 per page yields **$0.675** for a complete first read. Neither input is a verified figure for this book or month. A hypothetical $1 reader-acquisition cost would not be recovered by that one borrow. [S5]
- **Categories:** Romantic Suspense first; Contemporary Romance as a secondary candidate. A relevant small-town romance placement is worth considering if the current picker offers it. KDP permits up to three appropriate categories; there is no need to force a third. Verify the current marketplace/format choices, and do not promise a Short Reads placement from word count alone. [S6]
- **Series cadence:** Have Book 2 revised and ready, and Book 3 substantially drafted, before attempting releases **four to six weeks apart**. That is a proposed test cadence, not a proven ranking rule. Human quality control sets the practical speed limit.
- **Testing:** Test cover thumbnails, the blurb, and the opening with actual genre readers. Use a clear series link and a compelling Book 2 preview. Keep initial promotion bounded; track net royalties, spending, units, pages read, and demand for the next book. Aggregate page reports are not individual completion data; ask test readers directly where they skimmed or stopped.

AI disclosure: This manuscript is AI-generated under KDP's definition because AI wrote the prose. Human decisions and substantial later editing do not turn it into merely AI-assisted content. Disclose it to KDP. That requirement is distinct from requiring a public author note. [S7]

The research disagreement: The two underlying reports were not supplied. "Where sales concentrate" and "where an unknown short title can chart" measure different things. Category rank is not profit. One different book in each lane will be exploratory product testing, not a controlled test of whether clean or spicy performs better.

5. THE SKEPTIC

Verdict: I would not put my name on a romance whose central breach of trust receives less dramatic attention than starting its generator.

Rating: 2.5/5 as a publication-ready commercial romance.

Three biggest strengths

1. **Beth's job genuinely writes the action.** Chapters 1, 5, 6, and 9 turn work knowledge into decisions with consequences. The opening earns attention without any explanation of how the book was produced.
2. **The manuscript remembers its setup.** The binder, gate, buoy, and notebook are used with considerable control. I cannot fairly claim that the pipeline is unable to sustain a story. This manuscript demonstrates that it can.
3. **Tess and Ned give the crime moral substance.** "Nobody but Tess. Tess doesn't count" in Chapter 8 captures a community's ability to conceal betrayal from itself. The fuel loan and winter subsidy give the compromises recognizable motives. The space between Ned and Tess in Chapter 10 carries real feeling.

Three biggest problems

1. **The romance incurs an emotional debt it does not repay.** In Chapter 8 Beth says, "Your hands were on me. You were asking about the money." The next response is "Nothing." Dane's fear and orders explain his behavior; they do not answer her accusation. His report follows discovery, and sex follows the conversation that afternoon. Repeatedly saying "I chose it" establishes sexual agency, but it cannot settle whether her partner exploited an intimacy she understood differently. I want accountability and a changed agreement, not a prohibition on forbidden romance.

2. **Beth's intelligence is selectively suspended and then excessively rewarded.** Chapters 2, 5, and 6 keep her from connecting Tess to information she knows Tess possesses. Chapter 7 lets hurt obscure the exculpatory significance of the undisclosed fish house. Those can be believable mistakes if the narrative recognizes them. Chapter 9 then relies on deck familiarity, an injured marshal's struggle, and a gunman pursuing rather than firing again. Local competence is attractive; the plot still needs to resist the heroine.

3. **The emotional machinery is more generic than the marine world.** Dane's dead witness supplies a familiar protector wound; Marisol gets little existence beyond what her death does to him. The leads share clipped speech, guarded observation, and interrupted touch. Chapter 10 efficiently supplies the indictment, disciplinary outcome, transfer, Beth's relief watches, relationship, and series invitation. The neatness makes me feel the requirements being completed. If readers discover the generation history, these regularities could reinforce their dissatisfaction, but we have no evidence from which to predict backlash.

Change first: Have a human rebuild the Chapter 7-8 rupture and repair. Dane needs to own a choice, Beth needs an observable basis for renewed trust, and both need to want something together beyond surviving the case. Put the third sex scene after that altered understanding.

This is viable material. A generic "humanize the prose" pass would be a poor response: it could remove the distinctive surface while leaving the weak decisions intact.

ROUND 2 - CROSS-TALK

Disagreement 1: Must Tess be harder to identify?

KU reader: I do not need Tess to fool me until Chapter 8. I can enjoy dreading the moment Beth accepts what someone she loves has done. Let Beth suspect her earlier and struggle with the meaning; do not simply add another suspicious person.

Developmental editor: That can work, but it changes the design from a late-resolving mystery to suspense about an unavoidable betrayal. The current manuscript wants both and makes Dane incurious to preserve them.

Market strategist: I would not automatically spend the revision budget adding rival clues. The selling promise must match the chosen effect. Extra red herrings can add pages without adding a reason to finish.

Chair's reading of the disagreement: The editor's requirement is a deliberate choice of suspense model. The reader and strategist favor the emotionally richer early-suspicion version; they do not defend the current delay.

Disagreement 2: Change the heat, the prose, or the positioning?

Line editor: Preserve the restraint. Its repetitive expression is the problem. A sudden flood of declarations or hotter vocabulary would not repair Chapter 8.

Market strategist: Agreed on moderate-heat positioning. But a more accurate blurb cannot make forgiveness feel earned. Make the third scene depend on a stronger reconciliation.

Skeptic: Exactly. Dane needs to answer the accusation before their bodies are asked to answer it for him. I am not asking for another sex scene.

KU reader: The joke and the generator kiss already make me like them. Let the repair make the third scene hotter emotionally.

Disagreement 3: How much rebuilding does the climax require?

KU reader: I would preserve the showdown. Beth's knowledge of the boat is a large part of why I finished. Give Tess an immediate threat that makes waiting feel worse than acting.

Skeptic: I cannot excuse the risk solely because Beth knows the deck. The narrative has to establish why the safer options fail and acknowledge the cost.

Developmental editor: Repair the threat and information system first. Known terrain makes a plan executable; the immediate threat makes choosing it credible. A better reconciliation alone leaves that structural problem in place.

Ratings: No reviewer changes their rating. The disagreement is about the scale and order of repair, not whether this version is ready: KU reader 3.5; developmental editor 3.5; line editor 3.5; market strategist 3; skeptic 2.5.

ROUND 3 - CHAIR'S SYNTHESIS

Consensus rating and verdict

Consensus: 3/5 for the current commercial manuscript. Publishable after substantive revision.

TEN DAYS OUT has a viable core: a memorable working heroine, a specific island community, an integrated midpoint, and a climax assembled from objects and skills established early. Its three sex scenes serve the relationship, the second half escalates, and the ending completes the romance. The major weaknesses are causal and emotional: the leak is easier to identify than the brief intends, the protection system becomes selectively incurious, and the reconciliation is too abbreviated for the betrayal. Repetitive gestures and sentence shapes then make those weaknesses feel engineered. This is a promising first draft requiring developmental decisions and new scene work, followed by line editing and proofreading. It is not ready for a final polish and upload.

Five changes with the highest return, ranked

1. **Rebuild the information, extraction, and final-threat logic.** Audit every location leak, the rescue alternatives, the cash planting, and the reason to act before relief; give the final trap a concrete necessity and a shared plan that remains coherent when Russ leaves. **Backed by:** developmental editor, skeptic, KU reader, market strategist.
2. **Earn the Chapter 8 reconciliation and add ordinary intimacy.** Let Dane answer the assessment accusation directly, give Beth an observable condition for trust, and show what they enjoy or want together when neither is performing a rescue. **Backed by:** all five, with the KU reader and skeptic treating this as the first priority.
3. **Choose the mystery's intended reader experience.** Either add credible competing access and counterevidence, or let Beth suspect Tess earlier and make her emotional resistance the suspense; the chair favors the second approach because the community relationships are stronger than the decoys. **Backed by:** developmental editor, KU reader, market strategist, line editor, skeptic.
4. **Edit repetition across the whole book and distinguish the leads' voices.** Reduce duplicate hand gestures, mental filing, silence explanations, and object codas while preserving motifs whose meanings change; let Beth and Dane differ in humor, emotional expression, and how they reach conclusions. **Backed by:** line editor, KU reader, developmental editor, skeptic.
5. **Align the series and retail promise with the book's strengths.** Sell an open-door coastal romantic-suspense novella, make the next romantic reason to read explicit, and build release timing around revised inventory and actual short-book economics. **Backed by:** market strategist, KU reader, developmental editor, skeptic.

Continuity and logic findings

The following are specific textual discrepancies or missing steps, rather than claims that every specialist detail is wrong.

Location	Finding	Required correction
Chapters 2-3	Dane plans the two-o'clock return and declines the 9:15 departure; his later account says the assignment was to take her off on the morning boat.	Align the stated original plan and explain the lack of a safe mainland waiting option.
Chapters 4-5	Russ identifies the Ashby generator; Dane says he knows where Beth is. Their later Ashby access list nevertheless narrows to Ned and Dane, plus anyone Ned told.	Keep Russ in the location-specific knowledge list.
Chapters 7-8	The "Day 8, small hours" passage says low water was 10:05 and turned an hour earlier, implying about 11:05 p.m.; Beth later dates the church encounter to one in the morning.	Reconcile the clock, day label, and tidal safety margin.
Chapter 9	Russ leaves his gangway post; the text then treats the stern as the only open approach without securing the gangway.	Close, remove, or cover that access explicitly.
Chapter 9	The briefing places Beth in the wheelhouse; Dane later assumes she is coming down when the lights go out. The specified signal only establishes approach from the water.	Establish her descent in the shared plan or acknowledge an unsafe improvisation.
Chapter 10	Beth has climbed to Dane at the passenger rail when she reaches for "the next strap"; she goes back down to work the binders afterward.	Correct the blocking of the love declaration.

Additional causal gaps and clarifications: The Day 2 log's "no contact outside detail" needs a defined meaning, given the store visit and Beth's conversation with Ned. Explain when and why Tess is told to plant the $9,000 before the Friday bank bag leaves. Show the practical consequences of Dane missing a scheduled check-in for hours. State why Beth remains on the island until Sunday after relief reaches her on Saturday. These may have workable answers; the present draft does not sufficiently establish them.

Two apparent problems should not be overstated. The main calendar works: Friday is Day 1, Sunday the 22nd is Day 10, and Monday the 23rd is Day 11. The unrepaired transfer bridge also does not make Sunday's departure automatically impossible: passengers can use the brow, and trucks already aboard can unload at the intact mainland slip. Clarify the limited service and the reason it could not resume earlier. The draft also contains a scene divider at the Chapter 2 POV handover; this is not an established head-hopping error.

Specialist plausibility checks that matter to the story

Federal procedure: The Chapter 2 hearing timetable is not inherently impossible. The unsupported leap is that missing Monday's indictment necessarily makes this seized-drug case start collapsing. Current Rule 5.1 provides a preliminary-hearing timetable and permits extensions in specified circumstances; a hearing is not itself the end of a prosecution. A federal practitioner should supply the particular case reason Beth's appearance is indispensable, and review the assessment, disclosure, discipline, and licensing dialogue. "Coaching ends your testimony" in Chapter 8 is especially overconfident wording. [S8]

Extraction: The draft does give reasons - two weather systems, the broken transfer bridge, and a compromised landing. They do not fully answer LifeFlight, alternative pickup points, reinforcement after shots, or delay after the harbor clears. Coast Guard documentation describes the 47-foot motor lifeboat as capable of operating in much heavier seas than six feet; that does not prove a particular mission or landing is safe. It means the book needs a mission-specific restriction rather than an implied generic six-foot boat limit. [S9]

Physical aftermath: Have an experienced marine/emergency-response reader check the cold-water sequence, wound care and subsequent arm use, the fight around the trucks, and the handling of the near-drowned prisoner. These are verification tasks, not a claim that the panel has established every detail as false.

Publication decision and required human work

Decision: Publishable after a substantive revision pass, followed by a line edit and a proof. Do not publish this version as is.

A human must own the decisions that the pipeline currently explains away:

1. **Approve a revised causal outline.** Build a chapter-by-chapter record of who knows what, how it reaches the antagonists, why each safer option fails, and how the weather constrains both sides. Decide whether Tess's identity is a puzzle or an emotionally resisted recognition.
2. **Commission or personally make the substantive scene changes.** The key work is the rupture and repair, the final trap's necessity, and enough ordinary interaction to make this particular relationship desirable. Another general instruction to make the prose more emotional is inadequate.
3. **Obtain targeted human expertise and actual target-reader reactions.** Use a federal-procedure reader and a marine/emergency-response reader for the assumptions carrying the plot. Then give the revision to roughly 6-10 actual open-door romantic-suspense readers, including readers comfortable with novellas. Ask when they suspected the leak, where they skimmed or stopped, whether Chapter 8 repaired trust, how hot it felt, and whether the specific next-book premise attracts them. This is qualitative diagnosis, not a statistically representative market estimate.
4. **Complete a whole-book line edit, continuity pass, and device proof.** Check the revised text in the reading format, including scene breaks and navigation; replace the pen-name placeholder; approve the actual cover and description against length and heat expectations; make the required AI-generated disclosure to KDP. [S7]
5. **Approve the business test before setting the release date.** Have the next book ready, define success in net revenue and repeat demand, and cap the initial spend. The human does not need to rewrite every competent sentence, but must read and approve the final book rather than accept the pipeline's own pass/fail output.

What this says about the experiment

The pipeline can produce a coherent, distinctive, extensively usable first draft. This manuscript does not establish that it can produce a commercially viable finished book without substantial human editorial judgment. It demonstrates long-range setup and payoff, a sustained material world, functional romance structure, and scene-level integration. Those are meaningful results. Actual reader retention, willingness to pay, repeat demand, and profit remain untested.

Its weakest point is **global judgment about why scenes happen and what they earn**. A scene can satisfy its local checklist - heroine acts, threat escalates, sex changes the relationship, clue returns - while depending on a professional not asking an obvious question or on forgiveness the reader has not experienced. Repeated style instructions can preserve voice chapter by chapter while producing sameness across the book. The recurring mistake is to supply an explanation for a chosen beat instead of testing whether that explanation is convincing.

The pipeline therefore needs a review stage that reads the completed novel without the outline's intended answers and reports what is actually on the page. Track the reader's knowledge separately from the protagonist's knowledge. Audit causal links across chapters. Ask whether the emotional result was dramatized, not merely named. Keep human target readers outside the generating loop. This simulated panel is useful criticism; it is another AI output, and cannot validate the pipeline commercially on its own.

Finally, one clean novella and one open-door novella will test two products with many differences. Heat, cover, premise, execution, price, release timing, and series readiness can all affect the result. Treat the first releases as learning about audience fit and economics. The strongest evidence in this draft is that the pipeline has produced material worth a serious edit. The human value still needed is selecting the right story decisions, making the emotional consequences convincing, and judging the finished book as a whole.

SOURCE NOTES

Manuscript: supplied ten-days-out-full-draft.md, read locally in full. Quoted manuscript text is used for editorial criticism. Word count uses whitespace-delimited tokens and includes front matter and headings. All panel judgments are simulations. Platform sources checked 27 October 2026; recommendations and illustrative calculations are labeled separately from platform policy.

[S1] Amazon KDP, Metadata Guidelines for Books. https://kdp.amazon.com/en_US/help/topic/G201097560

[S2] Amazon KDP, eBook List Price Requirements. https://kdp.amazon.com/en_US/help/topic/G200634560

[S3] Amazon KDP, eBook Royalties. https://kdp.amazon.com/en_US/help/topic/G200644210

[S4] Amazon KDP, KDP Select Enrollment. https://kdp.amazon.com/en_US/help/topic/GD9PMU58BV24QFZ7

[S5] Amazon KDP, Kindle Edition Normalized Page. https://kdp.amazon.com/en_US/help/topic/G5HHMLVVEW48MQYW

[S6] Amazon KDP, KDP Categories. https://kdp.amazon.com/en_US/help/topic/G200652170

[S7] Amazon KDP, Content Guidelines. https://kdp.amazon.com/en_US/help/topic/G200672390

[S8] U.S. Courts, Federal Rules of Criminal Procedure, Rule 5.1, edition amended through December 1, 2025, printed 2026. https://www.uscourts.gov/sites/default/files/document/federal-rules-of-criminal-procedure.pdf

[S9] U.S. Coast Guard, Coast Guard inducts five motor lifeboats into Service Life Extension Program, September 24, 2021. Technical capability, not a guarantee of mission feasibility. https://www.dcms.uscg.mil/Our-Organization/Assistant-Commandant-for-Acquisitions-CG-9/Newsroom/Latest-Acquisition-News/Article/2787690/coast-guard-inducts-five-motor-lifeboats-into-service-life-extension-program/